

Play-Action, Bootlegs, and Screens

Passes that pretend to be something else: the run fake, the quarterback on the move, and the throw that invites the rush in

Second-and-3 near midfield, early in the third quarter. The offense has run the ball on six of its last eight snaps, and every time the defense's linebackers have shot forward at the snap and met the running back near the line. Now the quarterback takes the snap from under center, turns his back to the defense and pushes the ball into the running back's belly. Both linebackers take two hard steps toward the line, exactly as they have all afternoon. But the quarterback pulls the ball back out, spins the other way and runs toward the sideline, alone. The tight end who seemed to be blocking on the right side is now crossing the field ten yards downfield, behind the linebackers, waving his hand. The throw is easy, the catch is easy, and he runs another fifteen yards before anyone touches him. On the replay, the analyst circles a linebacker's feet: two steps forward, then a desperate turn. *That* is what this chapter is about: the passes that work by pretending to be something else.

You'll be able to...

- Explain why a run fake moves linebackers even against a team that cannot run, and what the data says about the old rule that you must "establish the run" first.
- Tell under-center from shotgun play-action, and a bootleg from a naked bootleg, a keeper, a leak and a shot play, from the first two seconds of a broadcast.
- Draw the running back's slow screen, the tunnel and jailbreak screens, the tight end screen and the middle screen, and tell any screen from a swing or flare route.
- Explain how a screen is timed, how the linemen release, and why screens get *better* the more defenders rush.
- Read a team's play-action rate and efficiency from charting data, and say which offenses lean on deception most.

You'll need

- **Dropback Concepts:** how pass concepts stretch a defender high and low or side to side, the quarterback's progression, crossing routes, and the yankee shot concept (a deep post paired with a deep crosser). Play-action passes are mostly those concepts with a fake in front.
- **Zone Running:** outside (wide) zone, the line stepping sideways together, the linebackers flowing with it, the unblocked backside end, and the first look at why outside zone and the bootleg are a matched pair.
- **Pass Protection:** the pocket, the launch point (where the quarterback sets his feet to throw), max protect, and time to throw.
- **Downs, Distance, and Field Position:** EPA (how much a play changed the offense's expected points; above zero is good for the offense) and success rate, for the data sections.

How to read the diagrams. Offense is blue circles, defense orange squares; *left* and *right* are the offense's. LT, LG, C, RG and RT are the offensive linemen, Q the quarterback, R the running back and F the fullback. Y and U are tight ends, X and Z wide receivers, and H a slot receiver. On defense, linemen are labelled by technique number in the under-center pictures and as T (tackle) and E (end) in the shotgun ones; S, M and W are the Sam, Mike and Will linebackers, CB a cornerback, \$ the nickel back, and FS and SS the safeties. Thin arrows are routes and paths, the thick dark arrow is the ball carrier, lines ending in a short bar are blocks, dashed orange lines are what a defender does in reaction, and the dashed brown arrow is the throw. The animations are simulated plays in Big Data Bowl coordinates (more on that at the end of the chapter).

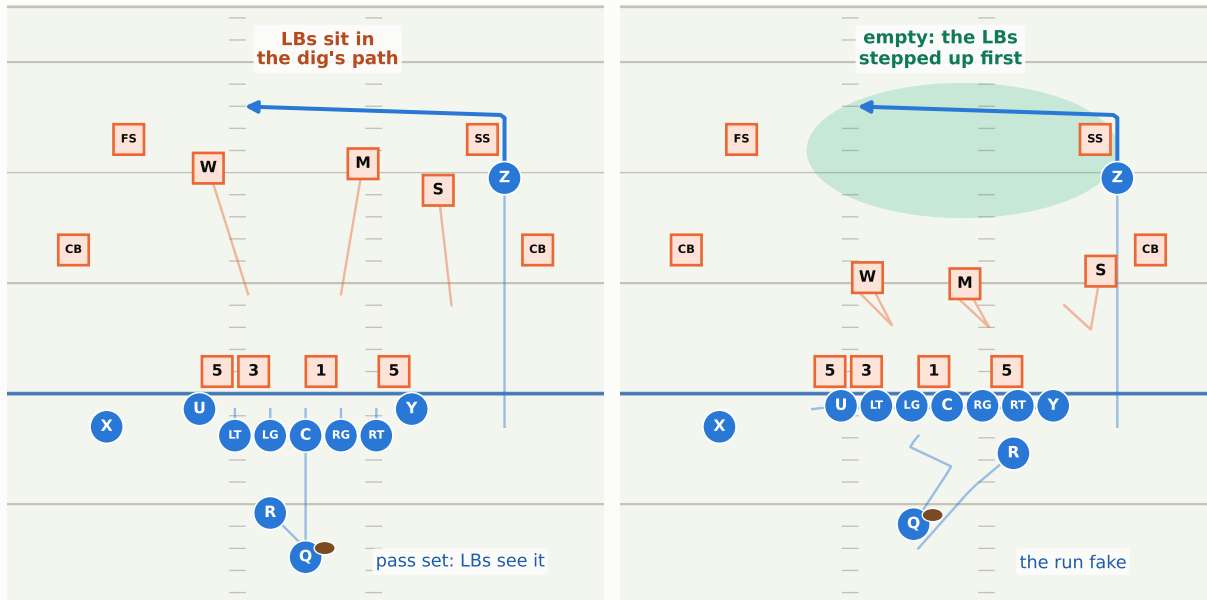
Why a fake works: the linebacker's dilemma

Start with the defender who is being fooled, because play-action is really a play *on him*.

A linebacker lines up about four or five yards off the ball, and on every snap he has two jobs that pull in opposite directions. Against a run he has a **gap** to fill (a run fit, the defense's plan for who fills which gap, built in Run Fits and Box Math), and he has to get into it *fast*: a running back hits the line about a second after the snap, and a linebacker who waits to be sure arrives after the back has gone by. Against a pass he has a zone or a man to cover, which usually means running *backward*, to a spot ten yards deep or to a receiver.

Play-action is built to pull those triggers on purpose. The guard fires out as if run-blocking. The running back takes the same path he takes on the real run. The quarterback reaches the ball out to him and pulls it back. For about a second, every signal the linebacker has been trained to trust says *run*. By the time he sees the quarterback still holding the ball, he has taken two or three steps forward, and he now has to stop, turn around and run back to a spot ten yards behind him. That second is the play.

Play-action: LBs about 5 yd deep



Compare the two panels of Figure 1. The receiver runs the same route in both. On the dropback, three linebackers are sitting at about the depth of his break, and the quarterback has to fit the ball between them. On the play-action pass, those same three linebackers are five yards shallower when the ball needs to arrive, and they are moving the wrong way. The window is not a little bigger. It is a different play.

Two rules shape what the fake can look like, and both come from the offensive line.

¹NFL Football Operations, *Official Playing Rules*, Rule 7 (ineligible players downfield during a forward pass): an ineligible player may not be more than one yard beyond the line of scrimmage before a pass that crosses the line is thrown: <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>; summary with the rule text at https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ineligible_receiver_downfield. The rule is taught in Run-Pass Options.

Second, **the defensive line is not fooled for long**. A defensive lineman fights the blocker in front of him on every snap, and he feels pass protection the instant the blocker stops moving forward. That is why play-action does not buy the quarterback extra *protection*; it buys him *space behind the linebackers*. In fact the quarterback is a little more exposed: he has turned his back or spent half a second faking, and he still has to set up and throw.

! Why it exists

Defenses have to stop the run quickly, so the defenders closest to the line are trained to react to the first signs of a run. Play-action turns that training into a weakness: it shows them those signs on a pass, gets them moving forward, and throws into the space they left. The price is time and protection. The fake takes half a second, the quarterback's back is often to the defense, the linemen are limited to the line, and the defensive linemen are not fooled at all. Play-action trades a little safety at the quarterback's spot for a lot of open grass downfield.

“You have to establish the run.” Do you?

Every broadcast you have ever watched has an announcer who says play-action works because the team has been running the ball well: the linebackers have been *punished* by the run, so they bite on the fake. It sounds like common sense. It is, mostly, not true.

The cleanest test came from Ben Baldwin, an analyst who later helped build the nflfastR play-by-play models this course uses. In 2018 he looked at whether a team's play-action passes did better when its run game had been working, measured several ways (rushing success that season, in that game, earlier on that drive) and found essentially no relationship: play-action passes beat ordinary dropbacks by about the same margin whether the run game was good, bad or barely used.² Josh Hermsmeyer, then writing for FiveThirtyEight, added the mechanism: linebackers react to run *action* on almost every snap, because reacting is their job, not because they have been convinced by a running back's stats.

You can rerun the test with the data this course uses. FTN's charters mark every dropback as play-action or not, and nflverse joins it to the play-by-play. Over 2022–2025, play-action dropbacks averaged +0.11 EPA against +0.00 for other dropbacks, and the gap was there every season.³ Figure 2 asks Baldwin's question of every team-season.

²Ben Baldwin, guest column on play-action and the running game, Football Outsiders, February 2018 (play-by-play charting, 2011–2017); Josh Hermsmeyer, “Can NFL Coaches Overuse Play-Action? They Haven't Yet,” FiveThirtyEight, 2018. Summary of both: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Play-action_pass. The same sources are used in Expected Points, EPA, and Success Rate.

³Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play (`load_pbp`) joined to FTN charting (`load_ftn_charting`, fields `is_play_action`, `is_screen_pass`, `qb_location`, `is_qb_out_of_pocket`, `n_pass_rushers`), 2022–2025 regular seasons. A dropback is any play with `qb_dropback == 1`, including sacks and scrambles, spikes removed. Running back carries for the run-game measure are runs by players listed as RB or FB on nflverse rosters, excluding scrambles and kneels. Data dictionary: https://nflreadr.nflverse.com/articles/dictionary_ftn_charting.html.

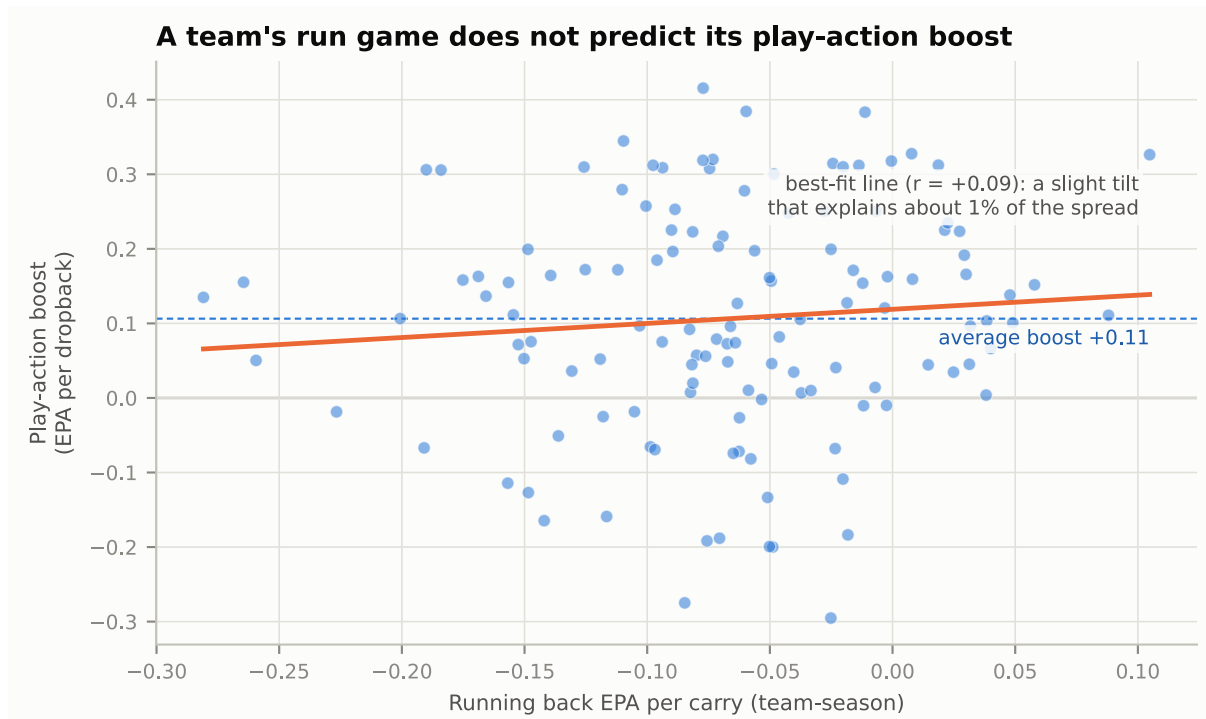


Figure 2: Does play-action need a good run game? Each dot is one team-season, 2022-2025 (128 in all). Across: how well the team’s running backs ran the ball (EPA per carry). Up: how much better the team’s play-action dropbacks were than its other dropbacks (EPA per dropback, play-action minus the rest). If a run game ‘set up’ play-action, the dots would climb to the right. They do not: the best and worst running teams got about the same boost from the fake. Data: nflverse play-by-play with FTN charting via nflreadpy; regular season.

The correlation between a team’s rushing efficiency and its play-action boost was +0.09, which is as close to nothing as real data gets, and play-action beat the team’s other dropbacks in 78% of team-seasons. Teams that *ran more often* did see a slightly bigger boost (correlation +0.24), which makes sense: a team that runs a lot shows the defense the run *look* a lot, and its fakes match its runs. But being *good* at running was not what mattered.

So what does matter? Coaches who build play-action games answer in one sentence: **the fake has to look exactly like your real run**. Same formation, same line steps, same back’s path, same quarterback footwork. A linebacker is not reading the season’s rushing stats. He is reading a guard’s helmet and a running back’s first two steps, and if those match the run he has seen all day, he moves.

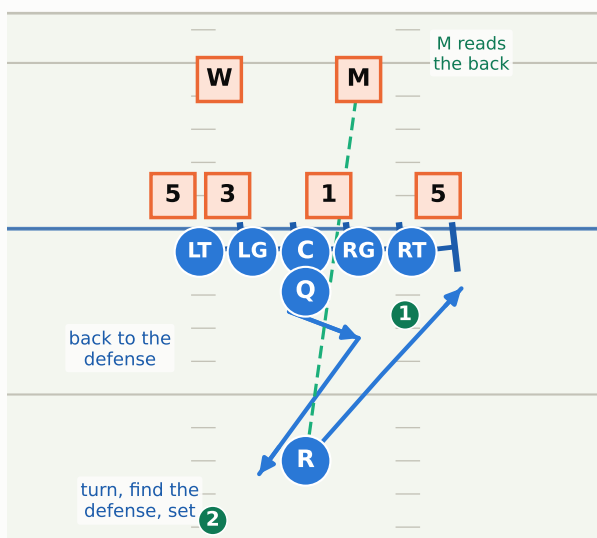
Common misconception

“Play-action only works once the run game is working.” The data says the fake’s effect barely depends on how well a team runs. What it depends on is how *similar* the fake is to the run, and to a lesser degree how often the defense sees that run look. A team with a poor run game can still have an excellent play-action game, and many have. The flip side: a fake that looks different from the real run (a sloppy handoff motion, linemen who pop up into pass sets) gets little, however many yards the back has.

Under center or shotgun: two kinds of fake

The quarterback’s starting spot changes what the fake can be, and you can see the difference from the couch in the first half-second.

Under center: a full fake



Shotgun: a ride and a pull

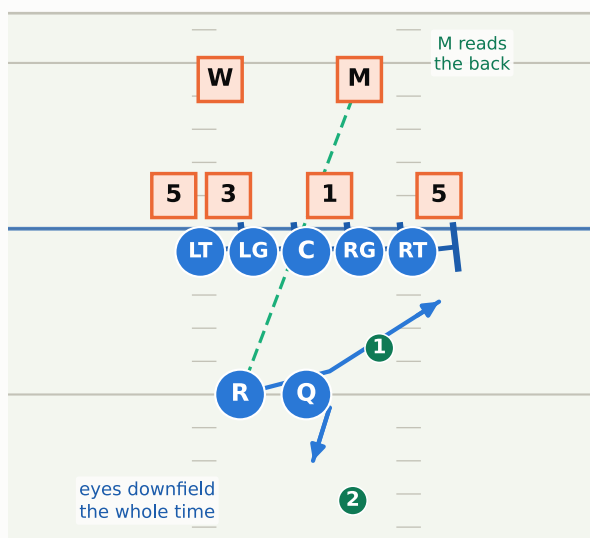


Figure 3: Two kinds of fake. Left, under center: the quarterback opens, turns his back to the defense and extends the ball to the back on the outside-zone path (1), then turns around, finds the defense and sets up seven or eight yards deep (2). For about a second he cannot see the field. Right, shotgun: the back runs across the quarterback's face, the quarterback rides the ball into his belly (1) and pulls it, never turning his head away from the defense (2). The fake is quicker, but it looks less like a real handoff, and the defense knows it.

Under center, the quarterback takes the snap, turns and carries out the same footwork as a real handoff, often with his back fully to the defense, and the running back's path is identical to the run. It is the most convincing fake in football, because it *is* the run for the first second. The cost is that the quarterback loses sight of the defense, then has to whip around, find his receivers and throw, often with a defensive lineman closing. Plays from under center are therefore usually built with a simple read the quarterback can find quickly after he turns.

From the shotgun, the back runs across the quarterback's face and the quarterback "rides" the ball into his belly for a beat, the same mesh as a shotgun run. The quarterback never stops seeing the defense, and the throw can come sooner. But a shotgun fake looks less like a run, partly because defenses know that most shotgun plays are passes.

The numbers make the split vivid. In 2025, 82% of all dropbacks from under center used play-action, against 10% from the shotgun. Under center has become, in effect, the play-action formation, which is a big reason it came back into fashion.⁴ And the fake from under center was worth more. Over 2022–2025:

Table 1: EPA per dropback by the quarterback's alignment and whether he faked a handoff, 2022–2025 regular seasons (FTN charting via nflverse). Under-center dropbacks without a fake are a small, unusual group (2,559 plays against 9,730 with a fake).

Dropback from...	No fake	Play-action	Boost
Under center	+0.08	+0.13	+0.05
Shotgun	−0.00	+0.08	+0.09

Read Table 1 with care: it is a description, not an experiment. Offenses choose when to fake, and they tend to fake in good situations (early downs, defenses expecting run), so part of the boost belongs to the situation rather than the fake. But the pattern is consistent with the football: the more the fake looks like a real run, the more it moves the defense.

⁴Same data and method as the previous note, 2025 season. The under-center comeback in personnel and formation data: see Classic Formations.

In Madden, play-action is a menu category: pick a play with “PA” in the name and the game handles the fake. In real football the fake is a skill that the quarterback, the back and the linemen rehearse every week, and it degrades if any one of them gets lazy. Quarterbacks are graded on their fakes. Running backs are coached to carry out the fake for several steps after the quarterback has pulled the ball, often running into the line with an empty hand, because a linebacker who sees the back stop knows instantly.

Where the fake sends the ball: three windows

What does the quarterback do with the second the fake bought? Look at where play-action completions end up. Over 2022–2025, play-action passes traveled about as far in the air as other passes (7.8 yards on average, against 7.7), but receivers gained **6.4 yards after the catch** on them, against 4.9 on other passes.⁵ The fake’s main gift is not depth. It is catching the ball with nobody in front of you, because the people who would have been in front of you stepped up.

That points to the three places a play-action pass usually goes:

1. **Behind the linebackers, in the middle.** The window in Figure 1: crossing routes, digs and shallow crosses that cross the field 5–15 yards deep through the space the linebackers just vacated.
2. **Behind the safeties.** If a safety reads run and comes down to help, the deep post or the corner route behind him is open. This is the *shot play*, below.
3. **To the side the defense left.** Move the quarterback the other way with the ball, and the whole defense’s flow is pointing at the wrong sideline. This is the bootleg.

The bootleg: move the launch point away from the flow

You met the bootleg in Zone Running as outside zone’s partner, and its ancestor, the Wing-T’s waggle, in Perimeter Runs and Misdirection. Here is the full play.

A **bootleg** is a play-action pass in which the quarterback fakes a run one way and then rolls out the *other* way with the ball, toward a group of receivers set up at three depths on that side. The name is usually explained by the quarterback hiding the ball on his hip as he rolls away, the way a Prohibition bootlegger hid a bottle.⁶ Two things make it work at once:

- **The run fake** pulls the linebackers and safeties toward the run side.
- **The rollout** moves the quarterback’s launch point away from that side, so the pass rush, which is aimed at where he *was*, has to turn around and chase.

The classic route combination is a *flood* of the boot side at three depths (the flood idea of Dropback Concepts): a short route to the **flat** (the area near the sideline just past the line), a **crosser** coming all the way across the field from the other side at 8–12 yards, and a deep route, often a deep crosser called the **over** route, 15 or more yards down. A receiver on the boot side runs deep straight away to clear out the cornerback. That gives the quarterback a simple read on the move: deep if it is there, crosser if the linebackers are trailing, flat if anyone comes at him.

Watch it move.

⁵Same data; pass attempts that were not sacks, 2022–2025. Air yards and yards after the catch are nflverse’s `air_yards` and `yards_after_catch` (the latter only on completions).

⁶The football sense of “bootleg” is usually traced to the Prohibition-era bootlegger hiding liquor on his body; the word itself is older (smugglers hiding flasks in the tops of their boots). Merriam-Webster, “bootleg”: <https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/bootleg>.

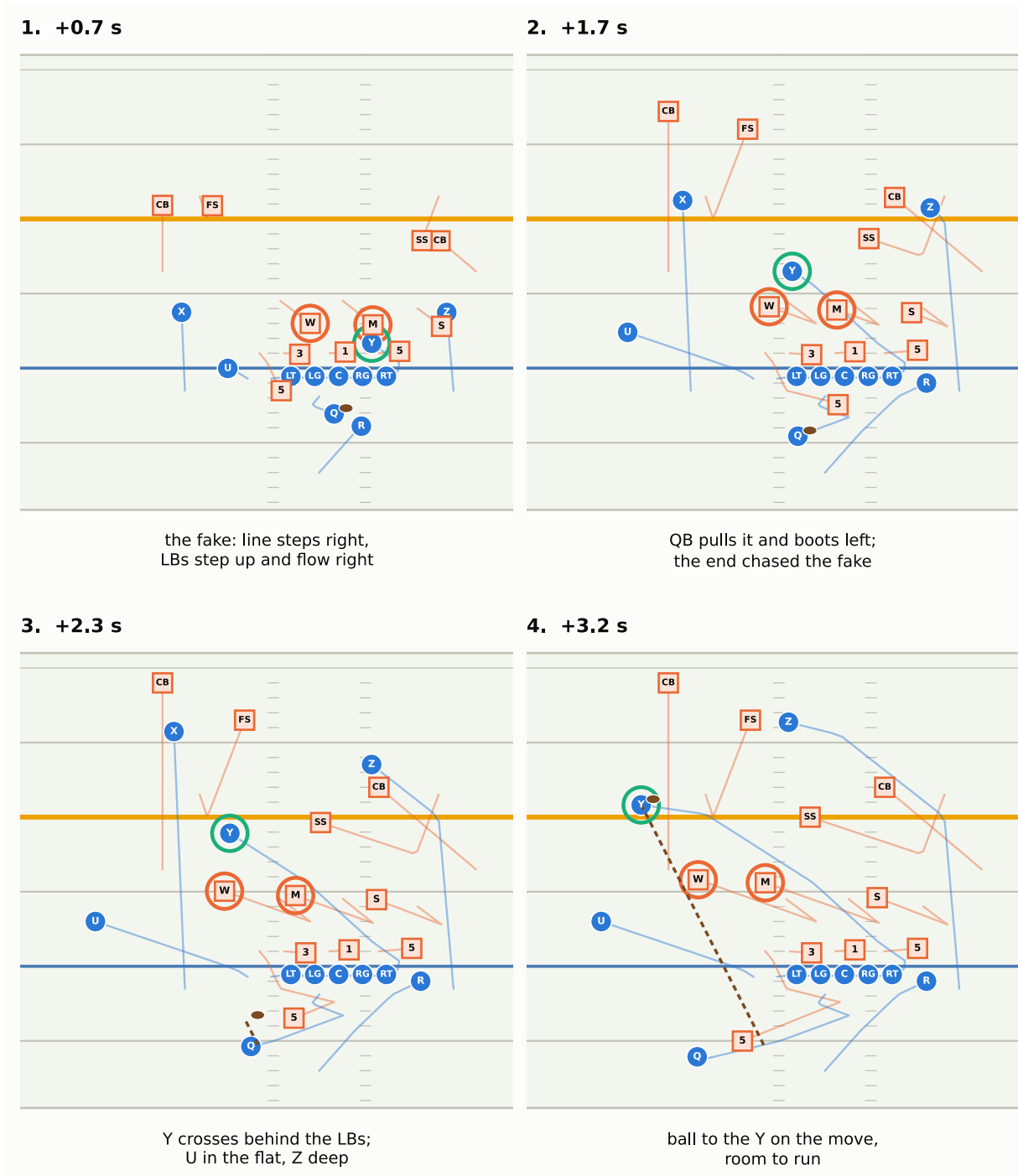


Figure 4: The outside-zone bootleg, frame by frame (simulated, BDB-format; faint lines show each player's path so far). The offense shows the same two-tight-end look and the same first steps as outside zone right (03-02). (1) The line steps right, the back takes the fake, and the Mike and Will (ringed) step up and flow with it. (2) The quarterback has pulled the ball and is rolling left; the backside end chased the fake and is now behind him. (3) The Y, who started on the right side as a blocker, crosses the field behind the linebackers, who are turning to chase; the U is in the flat and Z on a deep over route. (4) The ball goes to the Y on the move, with room to run.

Look at frame 2 of Figure 4. Every defender's momentum is going one way and the quarterback is going the other. The two linebackers who stepped up are now ten yards from the crosser and running *backward* to catch him; the cornerback on the boot side has turned and run with the clear-out; the backside end, the one man whose job was to stay home, chased the fake and is behind the play.

Now count the quarterback's options. All three receivers are on his side of the field, at three depths, and he is moving toward them, which shortens every throw. The read is usually **high to low**: the over route if the deep defender has gone with the clear-

out, the crosser if the linebackers are trailing him, and the flat if a defender comes up to stop the quarterback. If nobody comes up at all, he can run.

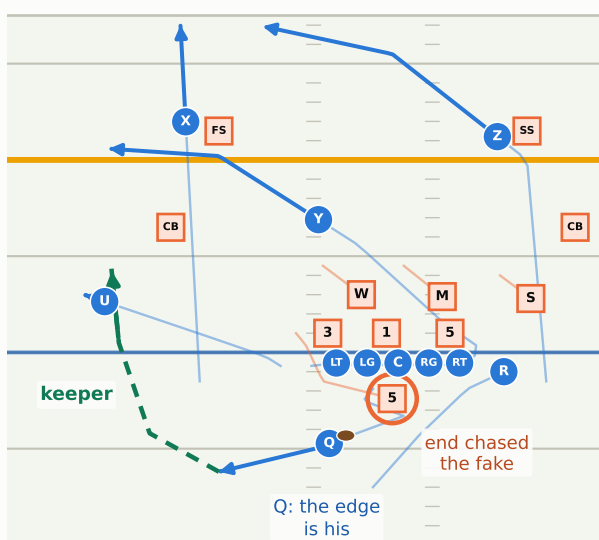
Why the defense struggles. It is not that the defenders are fooled for long. It is that they are fooled at the *start*, when the decisive steps happen, and then the play moves away from them. A defense that has been flowing hard to stop outside zone has been flowing correctly, every time, for three quarters. The bootleg makes the correct reaction to the run the wrong reaction to the play.

What the bootleg gives up. The quarterback is throwing on the run, to only half the field, with fewer receivers than a dropback (three, usually, sometimes four). Moving the launch point also moves it away from most of the protection: on most boots, nobody is blocking the man the quarterback is running toward.

The naked bootleg: nobody blocks the end

That last point is the bootleg's central bet, and the **naked** version makes it explicitly. A **naked bootleg** assigns *no one* to block the defender on the boot side, usually the backside end, the man zone blocking leaves unblocked anyway. The whole line and the back go with the run fake. The play is betting that the end will chase the fake, as he has been taught to do on the real outside zone run.

The end bites: throw or run



The end stays home: get rid of it

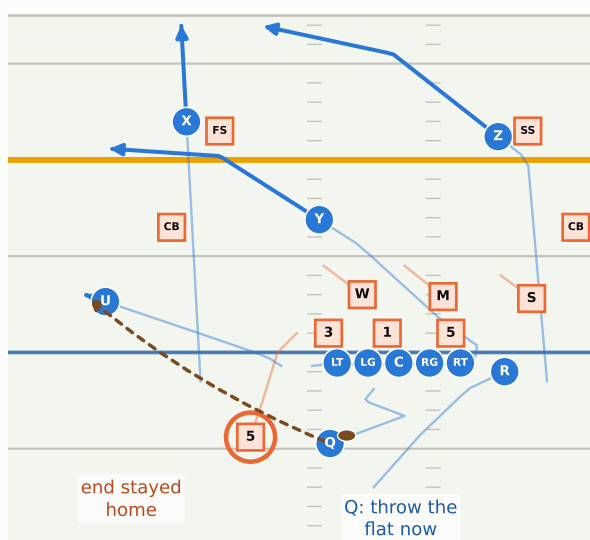


Figure 5: The naked bootleg's bet, frozen 1.8 seconds after the snap (faint lines: where players have been; arrows: where the receivers are going). The quarterback has faked outside zone right and is rolling left, and nobody is assigned to the backside end (ringed). Left: the end chased the fake down the line, so he is behind the quarterback, who has the edge: he can throw to any of his three receivers (U in the flat, Y crossing, Z deep) or, if nobody comes up, keep it and run (green dashes: the keeper). Right: the end stayed home and is attacking the quarterback. Now there is no time to read high to low; the quarterback throws to the flat at once (or throws the ball away).

When the bet wins (left panel of Figure 5), the naked boot is one of the easiest plays in football: the quarterback is alone on the edge with three receivers and a defense running the wrong way. When it loses (right panel), the quarterback has turned his back on a free defender. That is why the flat route is always there and always first if the end stays home: it is the boot's built-in hot throw, and the quarterback learns to check the end before anything else. It is also why offenses run naked boots *after* the end has been chasing outside zone all day, not before.

Keepers, protected boots and leaks

Three variations answer the obvious questions a defense asks of the bootleg.

What if nobody covers the quarterback? Then he runs. A **keeper** is a quarterback run off a run fake: he shows the handoff, keeps the ball and goes around the end the fake drew inside. On a bootleg it is built in (the green branch in Figure 5): if the end chased and the flat defender has run with the flat route, the quarterback's best option is often the empty grass in front of him. Some teams also call keepers as designed runs, and some playbooks simply call the whole bootleg a "keep." Either way, a quarterback who will run makes the defense pay for chasing the receivers.

What if the end stops chasing? Then the offense blocks him. A **protected bootleg** sends a blocker, usually a guard pulling from the line or a tight end or fullback, to meet the end on the boot side, exactly as the Wing-T's waggles did. The price is a tell: a guard running the “wrong” way, away from the run fake, is the first thing a linebacker who keys the guards will see.

What if the whole defense starts flowing to the boot? Then throw back the other way. A **leak** is a late release by a tight end or back who first sells a block, then slips into the space the defense has abandoned. On a bootleg, the classic leak is the play-side tight end, who blocks the end for a count as if the run were real, then releases into the flat on *his* side, the side the quarterback just ran away from.

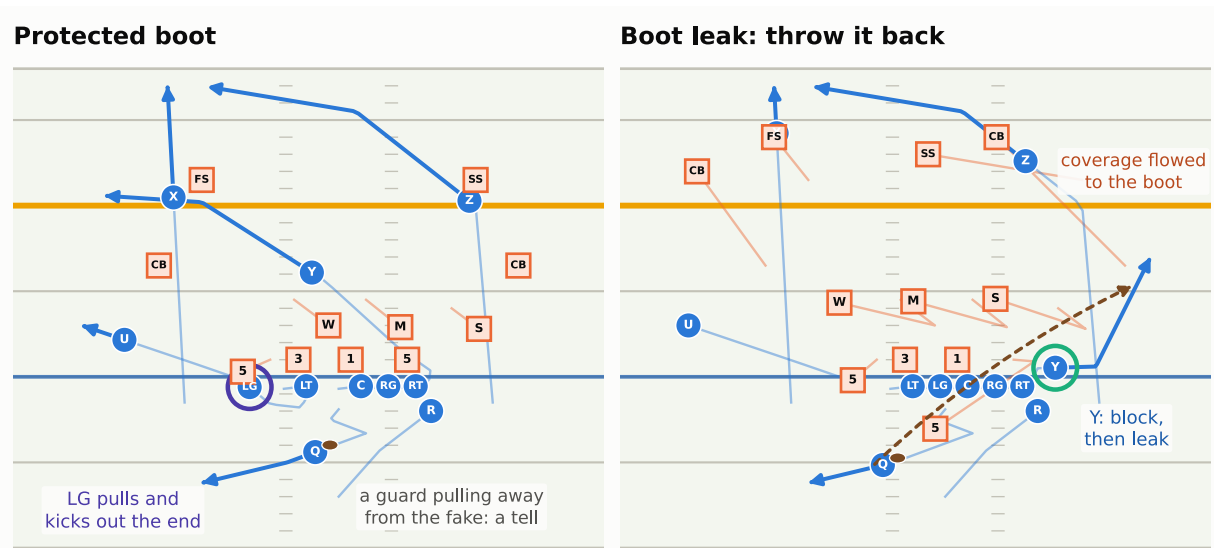


Figure 6: Two answers to two defensive adjustments, each frozen mid-play (faint lines: where players have been; arrows: where they are going). Left, a protected bootleg at 1.6 seconds: against an end who will not chase, the left guard pulls (purple ring) and kicks him out, so the quarterback has a blocker on the boot side; the cost is that the pulling guard tips off linebackers who read the guards. Right, a boot leak at 2.1 seconds: against a defense that has learned to flow to the boot, the quarterback still rolls left and the receivers still flood that side, dragging the coverage with them (the defenders' faint orange trails all lead left), but the Y (green ring) blocked the end for a count and is now releasing into the right flat, where nobody is left; the quarterback will throw back across the field (dashed brown).

Each of these is a reply to a defensive reply, which is the pattern of this whole chapter (and of Constraint Theory): the bootleg punishes the end and linebackers for chasing the run; the protected boot and the keeper punish the defense for adjusting to the boot; the leak punishes it for over-adjusting. None is a great play on its own. Together, they make chasing, staying home and flowing all wrong some of the time, which is all an offense needs.

How much of this do offenses actually run? FTN charts whether the quarterback threw from outside the pocket. From 2022 to 2025, the quarterback was out of the pocket on 30% of play-action dropbacks, against 15% of the rest, and those include scrambles; the difference is mostly designed boots and rollouts.

The shot play: the fake that goes deep

The third window in the list above is behind the safeties. A **shot play** is a play built to throw deep, usually 20 or more yards downfield, and called in a situation the offense picked for it. Most shot plays share three features, and each has a reason.

- **Play-action**, because the deepest defender that matters is a safety, and a safety who reads run takes a step or two forward. A deep throw needs only that.
- **Extra blockers**, often max protect with seven or eight men in protection, because a deep route takes three seconds or more to develop.
- **Only two or three receivers**, which is the price of the extra blockers. They are paired so that the one safety cannot cover both: in the classic yankee concept, a deep post from one side and a deep over route from the other.

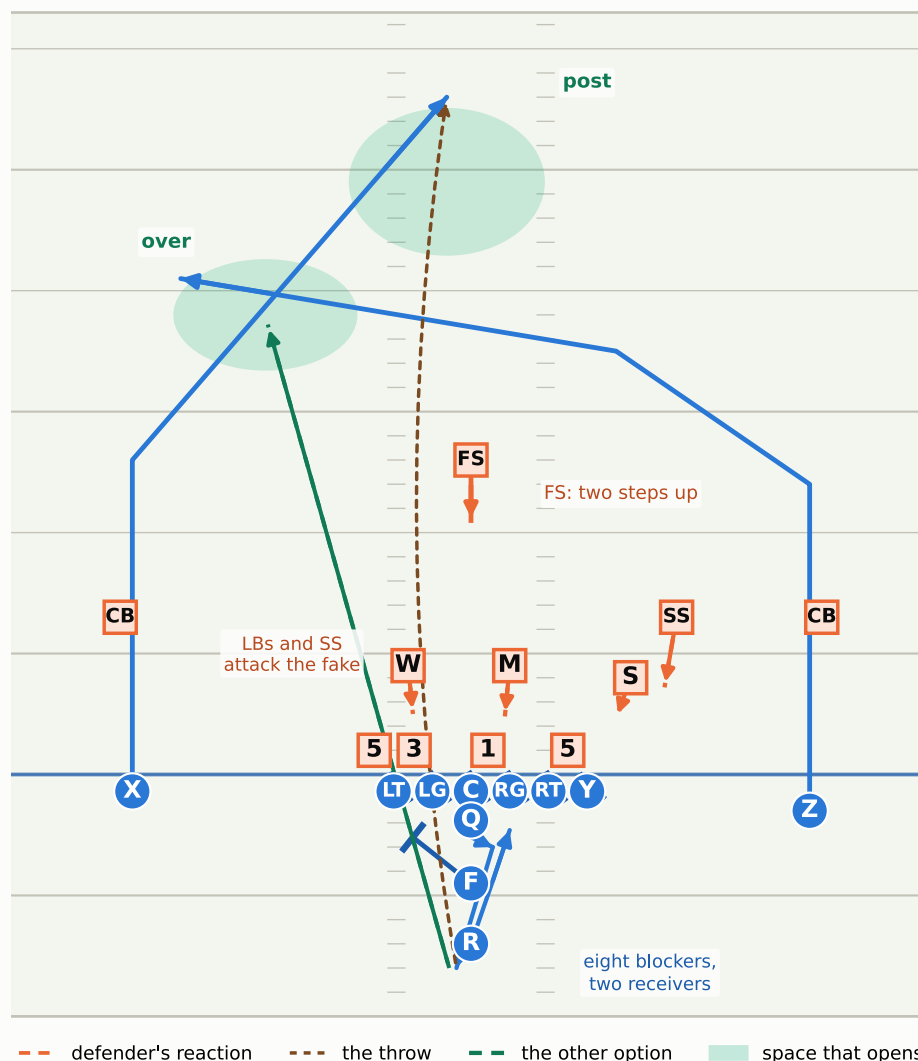


Figure 7: A play-action shot from the I formation against a single deep safety and eight defenders near the box. Eight blockers stay in: the five linemen, the Y, the fullback and, after his fake, the running back. Only two receivers go out: X on a deep post and Z on a deep over route (the yankee pairing). The fake pulls the linebackers and the strong safety forward and the free safety takes two steps up (dashed orange) before he can retreat. He cannot be in both places: if he stays on the post, the over is open in front of him (green dashes: the other throw); if he jumps the over, the post is behind him.

The defense in Figure 7 is the picture offenses want for a shot: one deep safety, the other safety down near the box, and linebackers who attack the run. That defense is built to stop the run, and the offense has usually spent the game showing it run looks from this exact formation. Situations matter as much as looks. Coaches like shots on **second-and-short** (an incompletion leaves a manageable third-and-short), right after a **turnover or a big play** (the defense is rattled and expects conservatism), and when the defense has just moved a safety down to stop the run.

Downs, Distance, and Field Position showed that NFL offenses mostly *don't* take that second-and-short shot: they run, and when they pass, they rarely throw deep. That is one reason the shot works when it comes. A defense that has seen second-and-short handed off fifty times believes the fake.

What the shot play gives up. Two receivers against a defense with six or seven men in coverage is a long-odds play on any single snap, and it has no answer if both routes are covered except a throwaway, a scramble or a sack. Coaches accept a low completion rate for the size of the prize: one completion can be worth more expected points than a whole series of short gains.

Screens: let them come

Now the opposite trick. Play-action pretends to be a run so the defense steps *forward*. A **screen** pretends to be a normal pass so the defense rushes *in*, then throws the ball to a receiver at or behind the line with blockers already set up in front of him. The rushers who came after the quarterback are now behind the play. The defenders left in front are outnumbered by linemen.

The quick wide receiver screens, the now screen and the bubble screen, were in *The Quick Game*: the ball comes out at the snap and the blockers are other receivers. This section is about the screens that use the **offensive linemen** as blockers, which changes everything about their timing.

A rule makes them possible. The one-yard limit on linemen downfield applies only to passes that are thrown *beyond* the line of scrimmage. On a pass caught behind the line, the linemen can be ten yards downfield when the ball is thrown, and on a screen they are.⁷

The slow screen

The original is the running back's screen, the **slow screen** (also called the **RB screen**). It is "slow" because it is built on patience: everyone on the offense pretends, for a count or two, that this is an ordinary dropback.

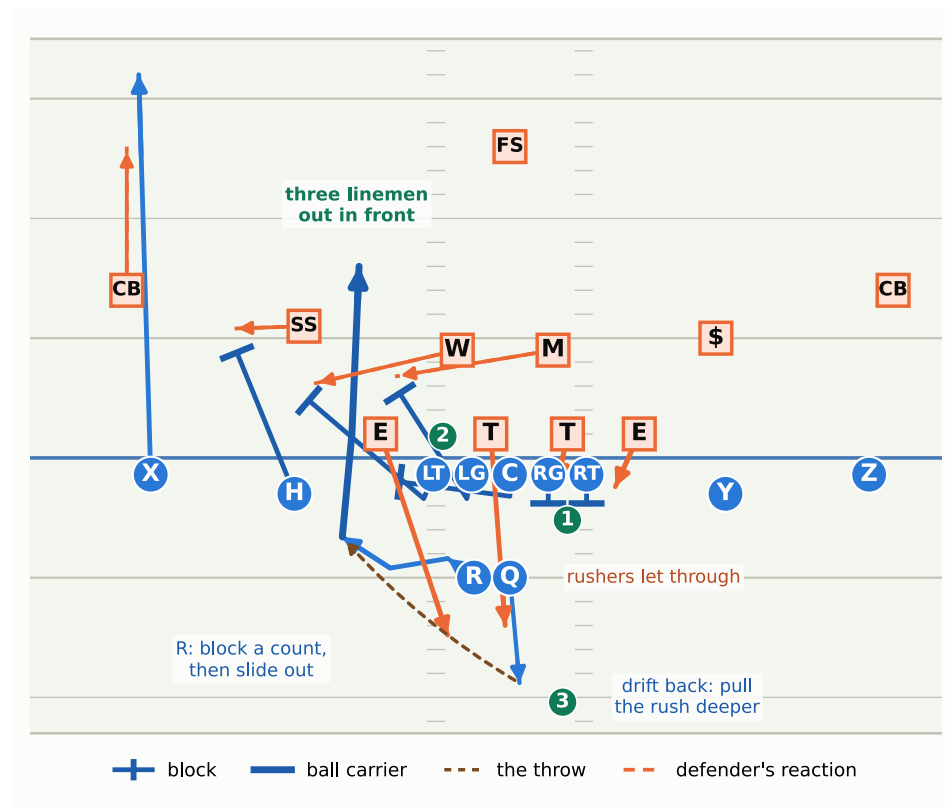


Figure 8: The running back slow screen to the left, against a four-man rush (all eleven jobs). (1) The linemen set as if pass-blocking and give a soft punch, and the back pretends to block. (2) On a count of about one-and-a-half to two, the LT, LG and C let their rushers go and release left, two or three yards past the line; the back slides out behind them. (3) The quarterback drifts back to pull the rushers deeper, then lofts the ball over them. Blocking in front: the LT takes the first threat outside (here the Will), the LG the Mike, the C turns back for the first chaser, X runs his cornerback off, and H blocks the safety over him. The RG and RT keep blocking their men.

Walk through Figure 8 in order, because the order is the play.

Sell the dropback. For the first second and a half, nothing looks unusual. The linemen pass-set, the back steps up as if to pick up a blitz, and the receivers run their routes, and those routes have a job: pulling the cornerback and safeties deep and away from where the ball is going.

Let them go. Then the three linemen on the screen side deliberately lose. Each gives his rusher a punch, then lets him run past toward the quarterback, and releases to the side. Line coaches teach the release with a count (it varies by team, but roughly "one-

⁷The one-yard restriction applies only when a forward pass crosses the line of scrimmage, so on a pass completed behind the line, linemen may already be downfield: NFL *Official Playing Rules* (see the first note) and the NFL's *Rules Digest* on the forward pass.

thousand-one, one-thousand-two”), because a lineman who leaves too early tips the play off and one who leaves too late is still in the backfield when the ball arrives. Each released lineman has a landmark and a rule: the first one out takes the widest threat, the next one the next defender inside, the center the first defender chasing from behind.

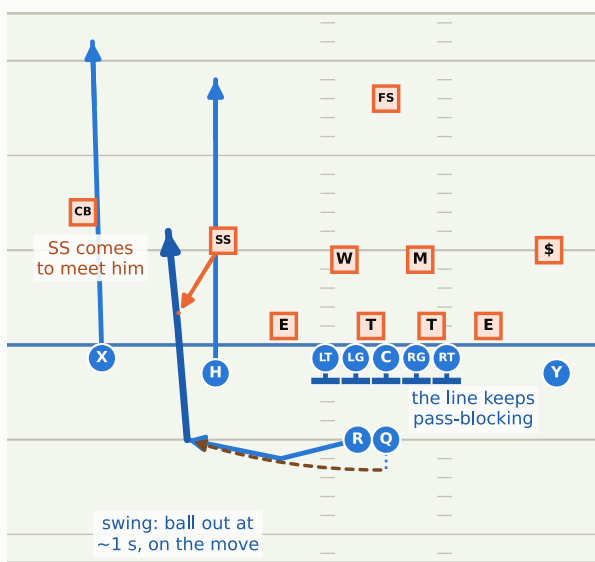
Pull the rush deep, then throw over it. The quarterback keeps drifting back, eight, nine, ten yards, dragging the rushers with him, then floats the ball over their heads to the back, who has slid out behind the released linemen. The deeper the rushers chase, the farther they are from the catch.

What the slow screen gives up. It is a timing play with a lot of moving parts and a low margin for error. If a rusher is *not* fooled (a defensive end who sees the tackle let go and stops to sit in the throwing lane, which coaches call “smelling” the screen), the ball can be batted or intercepted near the line. If the released linemen miss their landmarks, the back is running into a crowd. And it gives up the whole downfield passing game for one snap: the quarterback has one place to throw.

Swing and flare: not screens

Casual viewers call any short pass to a running back a screen. Most of them are not, and the difference tells you what the offense was thinking.

Swing route: no blockers



Slow screen: blockers out front

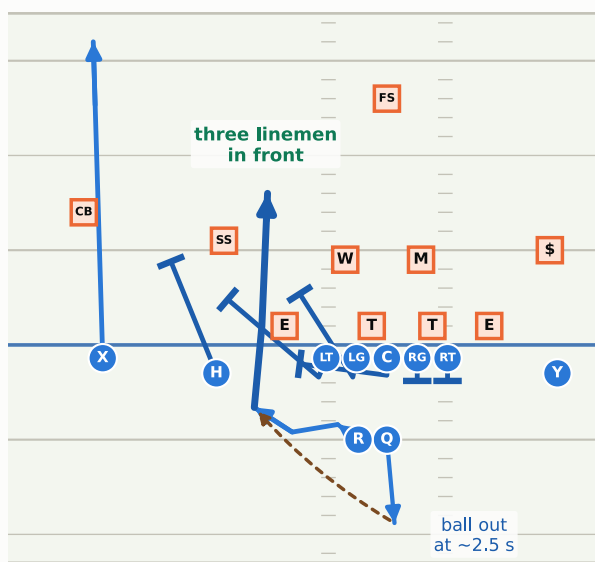


Figure 9: Swing route or screen? Same formation, same defense, two different plays. Left, a swing route: the linemen stay in pass protection, nobody releases, and the back bows backward and out toward the sideline and catches the ball early, on the move, with the safety over the slot coming to meet him (dashed orange). He has to beat that man himself. Right, a slow screen: the back waits, the left side of the line releases in front of him, and when he catches it he has three blockers between him and the defense.

A **swing route** is a running back’s route that bows backward and then out toward the sideline, so he catches the ball on the move behind or at the line. A **flare** is a quicker, flatter release toward the sideline that bends slightly upfield; many playbooks use the two words for the same thing. Either way, it is a pass *route*: the line keeps blocking, nobody releases in front of the back, and the throw usually comes early. Its purposes are different from a screen’s. It is an outlet when the downfield routes are covered (a checkdown the quarterback can always find), a way to pull a linebacker wide and open the middle for another route, and a way to get a fast back the ball in space against a slower linebacker.

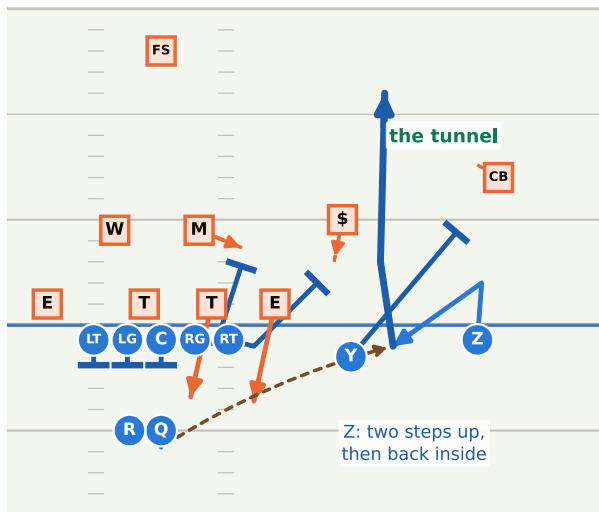
The tell on a broadcast is the offensive line. **If any lineman is running downfield before the ball is thrown, it is a screen** (or a run). If the line is still pass-blocking when the back catches it, it was a route. The second tell is the timing: the swing is thrown in about a second, before the rush arrives; the screen is thrown after the rush has arrived and gone by.

The screen family

Once you see the slow screen’s logic (let the rush come, release the linemen, throw behind them), the rest of the family is variations on who catches it and where the blockers go.

Tunnel and jailbreak: screens to a wide receiver

Tunnel screen



Jailbreak screen

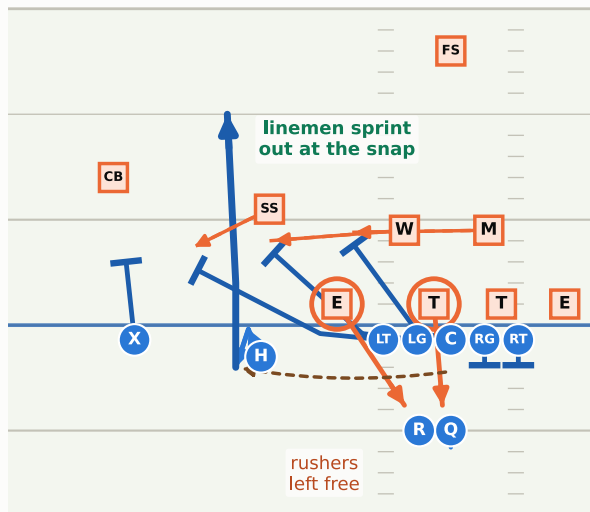


Figure 10: Two wide receiver screens that use the offensive line. Left, a tunnel screen to Z: Z takes two hard steps upfield to back his cornerback off, then comes back inside toward the ball and catches it behind the line. The Y blocks out on the cornerback; the RT and RG release outward and wall off the nickel and the Mike; Z runs up the ‘tunnel’ between them. Right, a jailbreak screen to H: at the snap nobody pass-blocks (the rushers are left free, ringed); the LT, LG and C sprint out to the left and form a wall in front of H, who steps back and catches a quick throw. X blocks his cornerback.

A **tunnel screen** goes to an outside receiver who comes back *inside*, toward the ball. The receiver’s first steps upfield matter: the cornerback, seeing a receiver attack him, backs up, and that cushion is the space the receiver catches the ball in. Two linemen release outward to wall off the defenders inside, and a teammate (here the Y, a tight end in the slot, a natural blocker) blocks the cornerback from the outside. The receiver catches it in the gap between them and runs up the “tunnel.”

A **jailbreak screen** gets its name from what the line does: at the snap, the linemen do not pass-block at all, they break out and sprint toward the screen side, leaving the rushers free. That makes it a *quick* screen, thrown in about a second, because nobody is blocking the rushers. Its advantage over the now and bubble screens of 04-03 is size: instead of a receiver trying to block a defender, a 310-pound lineman arrives in space against a 190-pound cornerback. Playbook names in this family vary a lot. Some teams call the tunnel screen a jailbreak, and some call any screen with the whole line releasing a “jailbreak.” The ideas are what matter: who catches it, which way he runs, and when the linemen leave.

Tight end and middle screens

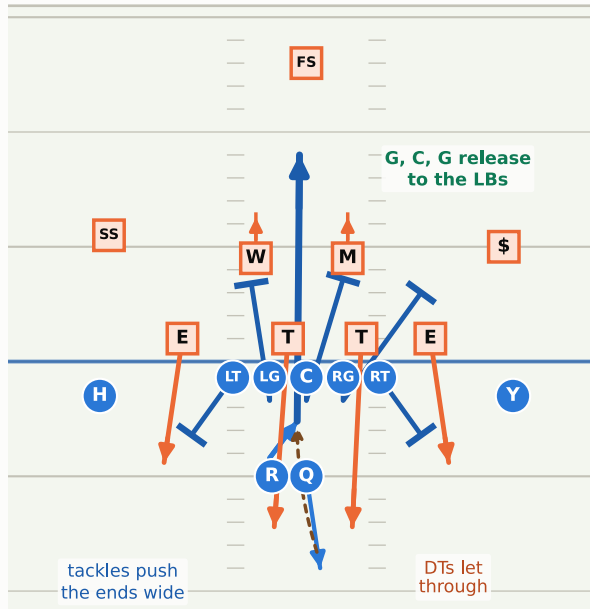
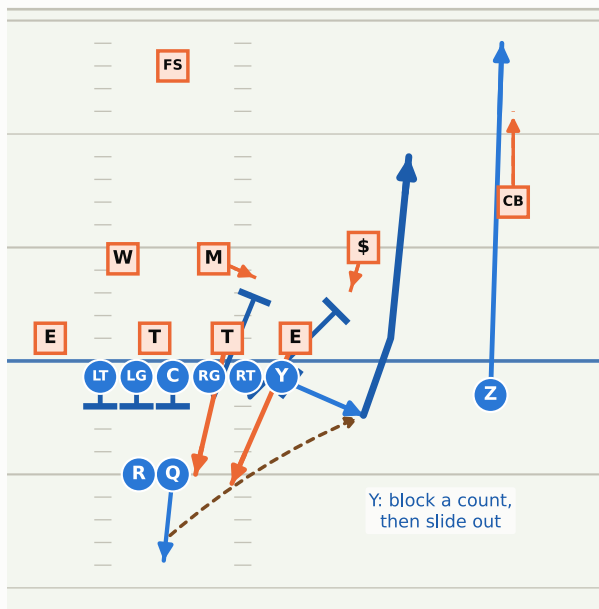


Figure 11: Two more members of the family (the receivers not involved are outside the picture). Left, a tight end screen: the Y blocks the end for a count, then slides out to the right flat behind the line, where the RT and RG have released to block the nickel and the Mike; Z runs his cornerback off. Right, a middle screen to the back: the tackles push the ends wide and past the quarterback, the guards and center let the tackles through and release straight upfield to the linebackers, and the back slips into the middle behind the rushers, in the space they left.

The **tight end screen** is the slow screen run with a tight end: he blocks the end for a count, which is exactly what defenders expect a tight end to do, then slides out behind the line on his side. It is a good call against defenses that bring the edge rusher hard, because the rusher is the man the tight end just let go. The **middle screen** puts the back in the middle of the field instead of the flat. The tackles push the ends wide, as they do on any dropback; the guards and center let the defensive tackles through and release straight upfield at the linebackers; the back slips into the space the defensive tackles just left. It punishes interior pass rushers who get upfield fast, and linebackers who drop deep on passing downs.

! Why screens exist

Every good pass rush has the same weakness: its rushers are trying to get *upfield* as fast as possible, toward the quarterback. A screen uses that against them. It turns the rushers' speed into distance from the ball, and it turns the five biggest people on the field, who are usually stuck at the line, into blockers in open space. The price is that a screen gives up the rest of the passing game for one snap, needs precise timing from seven or more players, and turns into a loss, or worse, if the defense recognizes it.

Screens punish pressure

The logic of the screen predicts something you can check: **screens should get better the more defenders rush**. Every extra rusher is one more defender running away from the ball, and one fewer defender in front of it.

Watch it against a six-man blitz. In Figure 12 the defense shows pressure before the snap: both linebackers walk up into the gaps beside the center (a double A-gap mug, built in Blitz and Man Pressure), and behind them the defensive backs play man coverage with no deep safety. Six rushers, five protectors plus the back.

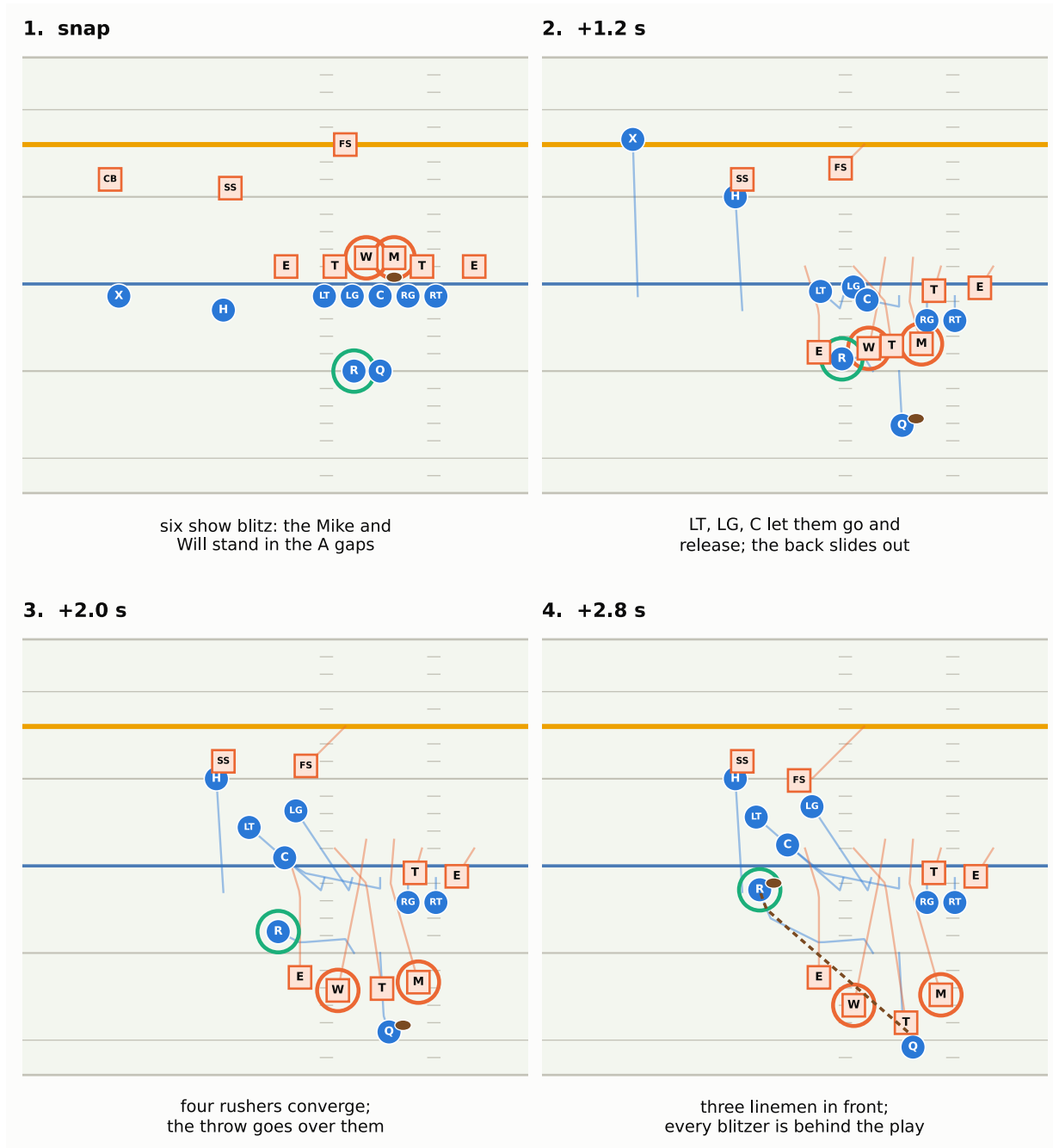


Figure 12: The slow screen against a six-man blitz, frame by frame (simulated, BDB-format). (1) Six defenders rush; the Mike and Will (ringed) come through the middle. (2) The LT, LG and C let their men go and release left; the back, who appeared to pick up a blitz, slides out behind them. (3) Four rushers converge on the quarterback, who throws over them. (4) The back catches it with three linemen in front of him and only the free safety, who was covering him from eight yards away, to beat. Every blitzing defender is now behind the play.

The data agrees, strikingly. FTN's charters count the pass rushers on every dropback, so we can split pass attempts by how many came after the quarterback.

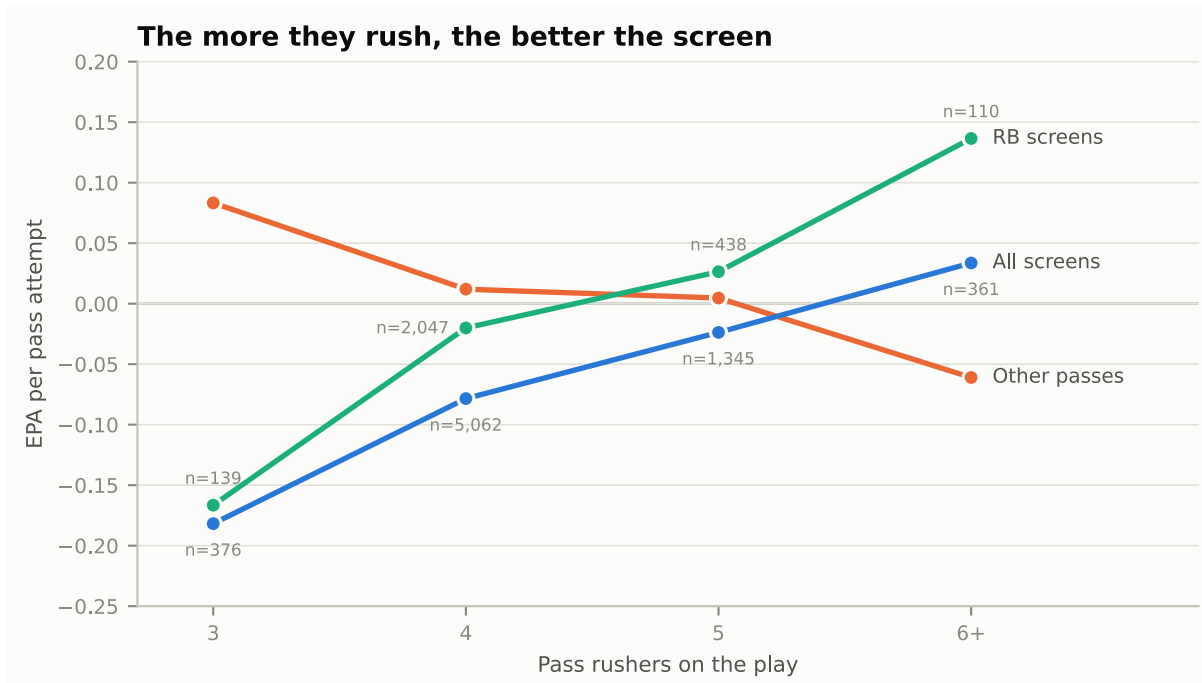


Figure 13: Screens get better as the rush gets bigger. EPA per pass attempt by the number of pass rushers, 2022-2025 regular seasons: screens of every kind (blue), running back screens alone (aqua) and every other pass (orange). Against three rushers (with eight defenders in coverage), screens are among the worst plays in football; against six or more, they beat ordinary passes. The six-plus group is small (labelled counts), so read its exact height loosely and its direction firmly. Data: nflverse play-by-play with FTN charting via nflreadpy.

Read Figure 13 from left to right. Against a three-man rush, all screens averaged -0.18 EPA per attempt: the defense has eight players in coverage and no rushers to fool, so the screen is just a short pass into a crowd. Against six or more rushers they averaged $+0.03$, better than other passes against the same pressure. Running back screens, the purest version of the idea, climb the most steeply.

Two cautions. First, selection: offenses call screens when they *expect* pressure, and a screen called into a blitz is likely to be the right call at the right moment, so these averages flatter screens a little. Second, the typical screen is not a great play: across all rush counts, screens averaged -0.07 EPA per attempt, below ordinary passes. Screens are not an engine of an offense. They are a **tax on pressure**: a play that makes blitzing expensive, so that the defense rushes four more often, which helps every other pass the offense throws. Screens made up about 8% of pass attempts in 2025, and 38% of screens over 2022–2025 went to running backs.

A short history

Play-action is as old as the legal forward pass (1906): as soon as a team could throw, faking a run first was the obvious way to make a defense hesitate.⁸ What changed over the twentieth century was how *systematically* offenses built it in. The Wing-T of the 1950s made the run fake and the bootleg (its waggle) part of a series in which every play looked like the others, the idea you met in 03-05.

The modern NFL bootleg game runs through **Mike Shanahan** and **Gary Kubiak** in Denver. Kubiak was the Broncos' offensive coordinator from 1995 through 2005 under Shanahan, the same years Alex Gibbs installed the outside zone run game of 03-02, and John Elway, then in his mid-thirties and hardly a scrambler, made a career's final act out of faking the stretch and rolling away from it. The pairing became a coaching tree's signature. Kyle Shanahan, Mike's son, was the Atlanta Falcons' offensive coordinator in 2016, when Matt Ryan, throwing off play-action and boots, was named the league's MVP; Kyle took the system to San Francisco as head coach in 2017, and his staffs produced Sean McVay, Matt LaFleur and others.⁹

⁸The forward pass became legal in American football in 1906, after the rules reforms of 1905–06: Pro Football Hall of Fame, "Forward pass" history, and https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Forward_pass.

⁹Gary Kubiak was Denver's offensive coordinator 1995–2005 (Pro Football Reference coaching page: <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/coaches/KubiGa0.htm>). Matt Ryan was the 2016 AP MVP with Kyle Shanahan as Atlanta's offensive coordinator (<https://www.pro-football-reference.com/years/2016/>; <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/coaches/ShanKy0.htm>). The tree is traced in Zone Running and the 12-03 case study.

Then the data caught up with the coaches. In 2018 Sean McVay's Rams went 13–3 and reached the Super Bowl with Jared Goff throwing off play-action more than any quarterback in the league, on roughly a third of his dropbacks.¹⁰ In the same year Baldwin and Hermsmeyer published the analyses described above, showing that play-action's value did not depend on the run game. Play-action rates rose across the league afterward. In FTN's charting the league used play-action on 21% of dropbacks in 2022 and 23% in 2025, with the return of the under-center formation (see Classic Formations) helping push it up.

Screens are just as old, and no one owns them. The screen game most associated with the modern NFL is **Andy Reid's**. Reid learned the West Coast offense under Mike Holmgren in Green Bay, and from his first years as a head coach in Philadelphia (from 1999) his teams threw running back screens as a core play, not a gimmick, with Brian Westbrook as their best-known weapon in the 2000s. He took the same habits to Kansas City in 2013.¹¹

Film room: Los Angeles Rams 2018

The season: McVay's second year, 13–3, a loss to New England in Super Bowl LIII. Goff threw off play-action more often than any other quarterback, nearly always from the same 11-personnel, tight-split formations the Rams used for their outside zone runs with Todd Gurley (see the film room in Spread and Modern Formations).

What to notice:

- The *match*. Line steps, back's path and receivers' splits are identical on the run and the fake. Try to call run or pass from the first step; you will be wrong often, and so were linebackers.
- The *crossers*. A large share of the big plays are receivers running across the field at 10–15 yards, behind linebackers who stepped up: the window of Figure 1.
- The *boots*. Goff rolling away from outside zone with the flat, crosser and over routes, often after pre-snap motion has moved a receiver to the boot side.
- What went wrong in the Super Bowl: New England played far more man coverage and squeezed the crossers, and the Rams scored three points. A play-action game still needs receivers to beat coverage.

Film room: Seattle Seahawks 2025

The season: Klint Kubiak's one year as Seattle's offensive coordinator, with Sam Darnold at quarterback, ending in a 29–13 win over New England in Super Bowl LX.¹² Kubiak is Gary Kubiak's son, and his offense was the Denver tree in its 2025 form: outside zone from tight formations and the boots and play-action that pair with it. In FTN's charting, Seattle's play-action dropbacks averaged +0.40 EPA, against +0.02 on its other dropbacks, the biggest gap in the league (Figure 14).

What to do: watch any Seahawks game from 2025 and keep two counts: how many dropbacks start with a run fake, and how many of those move the quarterback out of the pocket. Then watch the linebackers on each fake with this chapter's checklist. Kubiak was hired as the Raiders' head coach for 2026, so this was one season's offense, not Seattle's current one.

¹⁰2018 Rams record and Super Bowl LIII (lost 13–3 to New England): Pro Football Reference, <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/teams/ram/2018.htm>. Goff's play-action usage, the league's highest in 2018 at roughly a third of his dropbacks, is from contemporary charting (PFF and ESPN) summarized in https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Play-action_pass.

¹¹Reid was a Packers assistant under Holmgren 1992–98, Eagles head coach 1999–2012 and Chiefs head coach from 2013: <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/coaches/ReidAn0.htm>. On Westbrook as the Eagles' screen weapon: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Brian_Westbrook.

¹²Super Bowl LX, February 8, 2026: Seattle 29, New England 13 (see the course fact sheet): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_LX. Seattle's 2025 staff and quarterback: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2025_Seattle_Seahawks_season.

i Film room: Kansas City Chiefs 2022–2025, the screen game

The record: in FTN’s charting, the Chiefs threw 327 screens over the four seasons, more than any other team, and averaged +0.11 EPA on them, when the league average screen was worth −0.07. Most teams use screens as a tax on pressure; Reid’s offense gets value from them.

What to notice:

- The *sell*. Watch the Chiefs’ linemen on a running back screen: they pass-set, punch and give ground as if in a real protection before releasing. A lazy release is the most common way screens die, and Kansas City’s rarely look lazy.
- The *variety*. Running back slow screens, tunnel screens to receivers, tight end screens, screens off play-action and screens after motion: the defense cannot simply key one look.
- The *timing against pressure*. Watch what the Chiefs call on downs when an opponent has been blitzing; the screen is often the punishment.

The numbers: who fakes, and does it work?

Now the league-wide picture. In 2025 offenses used play-action on 23% of dropbacks, and those dropbacks averaged +0.12 EPA, against +0.02 for dropbacks without a fake; their success rate was 49% against 45%. Figure 14 breaks that down by team.

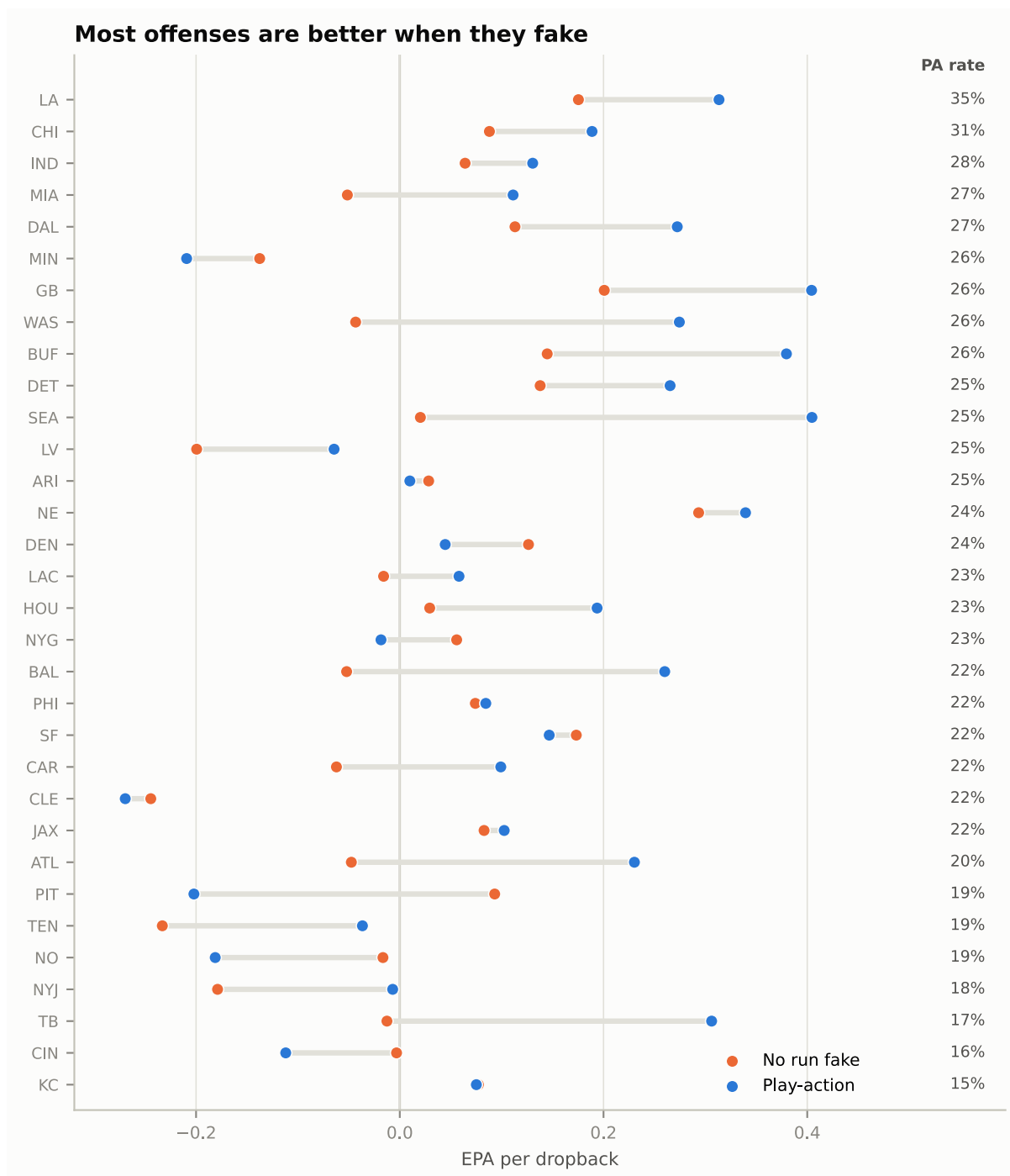


Figure 14: Play-action by team, 2025 regular season. Each row is a team: EPA per dropback without a run fake (orange) and with one (blue); the line between them is the boost the fake gave that team. The right-hand column is the team's play-action rate (share of its dropbacks that began with a fake). Teams are sorted by that rate. Data: nflverse play-by-play with FTN charting via nflreadpy; dropbacks include sacks and scrambles.

Three things stand out in Figure 14.

Most teams were better with the fake. 22 of 32 offenses averaged more EPA on play-action dropbacks than on their others. That is a single season, and some teams' play-action samples are only a hundred-odd plays, so individual gaps bounce around from year to year. The league-wide pattern does not.

The heaviest users were the Shanahan-tree offenses and their cousins. The Rams led the league at 35%. You will find McVay's Rams, Ben Johnson's Bears and Kubiak's Seahawks near the top: offenses whose run game and pass game are designed to look alike.

Some good offenses barely fake. The lowest rates belong to teams built around a shotgun quarterback who wins from the pocket, where a fake looks less like a run (the Chiefs were near the bottom). Low use is a style, not a mistake: a fake is worth most when it looks like your real run, and some offenses' real runs are not the ones defenses fear.

Why doesn't everyone fake on every snap, if it is worth that much? Partly selection again: offenses fake when the situation makes the run believable (first-and-10, second-and-short), and the extra EPA partly belongs to those situations. And partly because a fake only works while the defense must respect the run. On third-and-9, nobody bites.

Common misconception

"Play-action is a deep-ball play." Some of it is, but the biggest difference in the data is *after* the catch. Over 2022–2025 play-action passes traveled about as far in the air as other passes but gained about 1.5 more yards after the catch on average. The typical play-action completion is a crosser or a boot route caught in space vacated by a linebacker, not a bomb.

Watch for it on Sunday

Watch for it: the linebackers' feet

Before the snap

- **Under center?** About four of every five under-center dropbacks begin with a run fake. When the quarterback lines up under the center, think run *or* play-action, not dropback.
- **The run look.** Two tight ends, a back seven yards deep, receivers in tight splits: this is the formation the offense runs outside zone from, which makes it the formation it fakes from.
- **The down and distance.** First-and-10 and second-and-short are play-action downs; third-and-long is not.

At the snap: watch the linebackers' feet, not the ball

- Did they step *forward*? Count the steps. Two steps up on a fake is a win for the offense.
- Did the guard in front of them fire out low, or pop up? If he popped up and they stayed home, the fake did not work, and the throw will be harder.

In the first two seconds

- Did the quarterback turn his back to the defense (under-center fake) or ride the back (shotgun)?
- Did he roll away from the fake? Find the backside end: did he chase (the boot wins) or stay home (watch for the quick throw to the flat, or a protected boot with a pulling guard)?
- **Linemen running downfield before the throw?** It's a screen. Which ones released, and to which side? Did the rushers run past the back?

After the play (on the replay)

- How many yards did the crosser gain *after* the catch? That is the space the linebackers left.
- On a screen, count the blockers in front of the catch and the rushers behind it.

For your prediction log (How to Watch a Broadcast): on every under-center snap, write *run*, *PA* or *boot* before the snap. Then, when the defense blitzes on a passing down, write *screen?* and see how often you are right.

Predict the play

💡 Predict the play 1: the shot

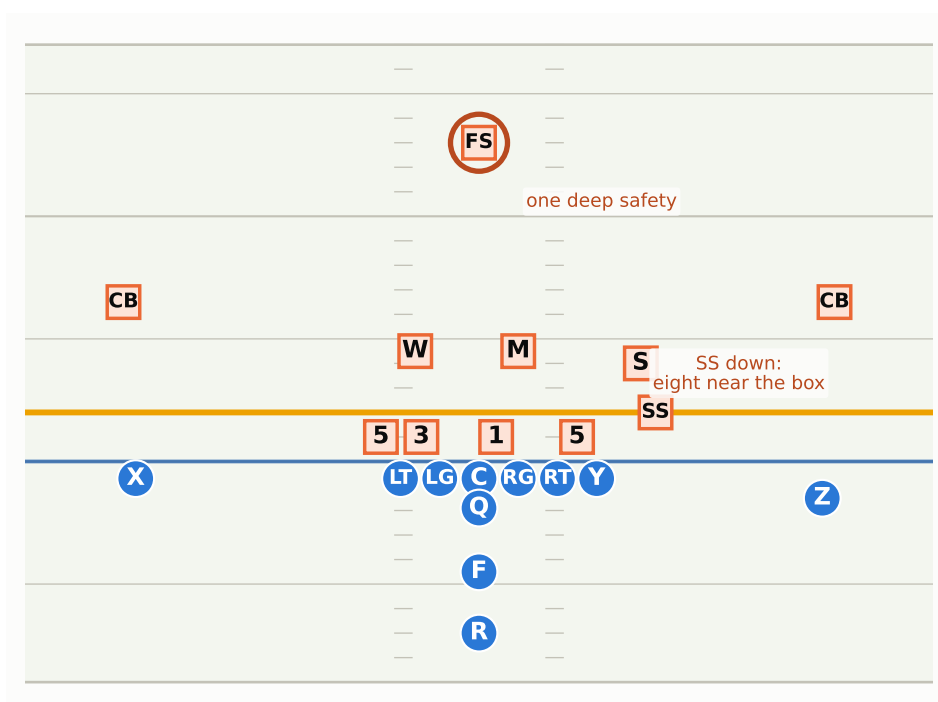


Figure 15: Second-and-2 at midfield, third quarter. The offense is in 21 personnel in the I formation. The defense has walked its strong safety down to the line of scrimmage on the tight end's side and has one deep safety (ringed), about 13 yards off the ball. It has stopped the last three runs near the line, its linebackers shooting forward at the snap.

The offense has run the ball six times in its last eight plays. What should it call here, and what is the one defender the play is aimed at?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 2: the end who won't bite

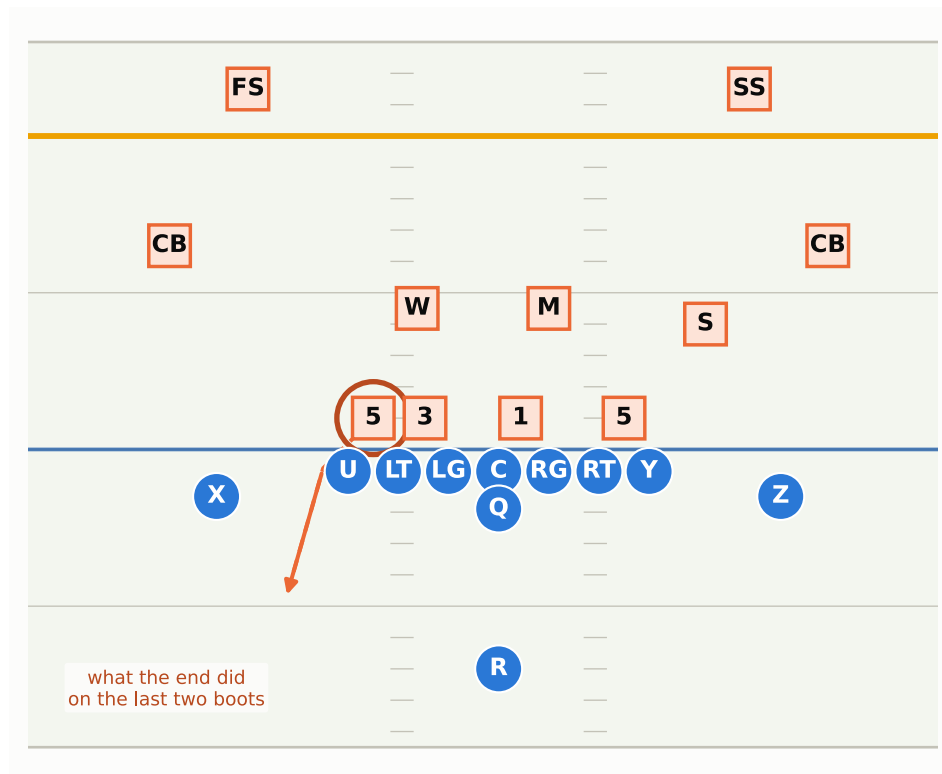


Figure 16: Same two-tight-end look the offense has run outside zone right from all game. On each of its last two naked bootlegs left, the backside end (ringed) did not chase the run fake: he stepped upfield and outside and waited for the quarterback (dashed orange), and both times the quarterback had to throw the ball away. It is first-and-10.

What has the end taken away, what has he given up, and what are two good calls from this look?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 3: name it after the snap

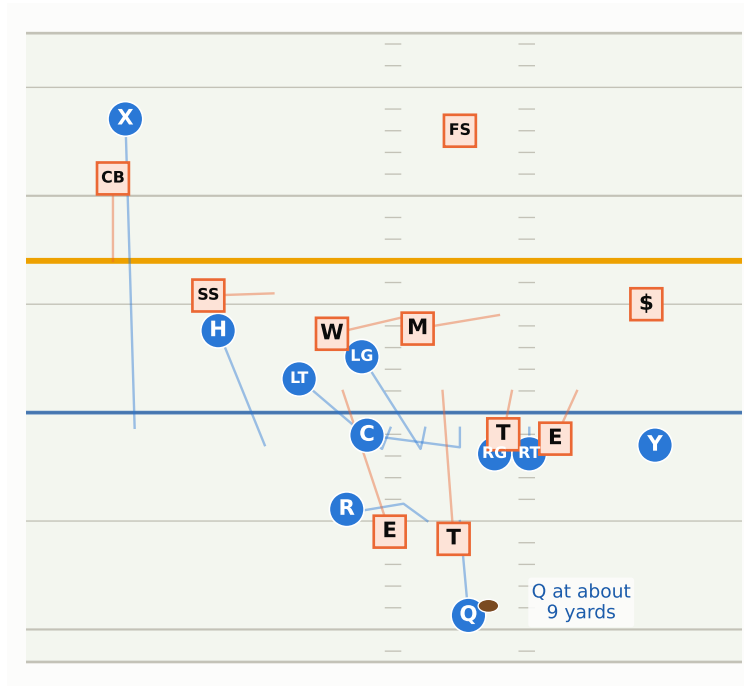


Figure 17: Third-and-7, shotgun, 11 personnel. The picture is frozen 1.9 seconds after the snap; the faint lines show where every player has come from (offense blue, defense orange). Look at the offensive linemen on the left, the running back, and the quarterback's depth.

What play is this, which side is it going to, and why is it legal for the left tackle, left guard and center to be past the line of scrimmage?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- **Play-action works on the linebackers' run-fit triggers.** Defenders near the line must react to run signals fast; a fake that shows those signals (low line steps, the back's path, the handoff) moves them forward and opens the space behind them. It buys space, not protection.
- **It does not need a good run game.** Baldwin's 2018 analysis and this chapter's 2022–2025 rerun agree: a team's rushing efficiency barely predicts its play-action boost. What matters is that the fake **looks exactly like the real run**. Under-center fakes, the most convincing, are worth the most.
- The fake sends the ball to **three windows**: behind the linebackers (crossers, most of the value, much of it after the catch), behind the safeties (the **shot play**, with extra blockers and two or three receivers), and to the side the defense left (the **bootleg**).
- The **bootleg** moves the launch point away from the defense's flow, with three receivers at three depths. The **naked boot** bets that the end chases; the **keeper**, the **protected boot** and the **leak** answer the defense's adjustments to it.
- A **screen** invites the rush, releases linemen in front of a receiver behind the line (legal, because the pass does not cross the line) and throws over the rushers. **Slow, tunnel, jailbreak, tight end and middle** screens vary who catches it and where the blockers go. A **swing** or **flare** is a route, not a screen: nobody releases to block.
- **Screens punish pressure.** Their value climbs with every extra rusher; against a soft rush they are among the worst plays in football. They are a tax that keeps defenses from blitzing freely.

Connections

Builds on: Zone Running (outside zone, the unblocked backside end and the first look at the bootleg), Perimeter Runs and Misdirection (the Wing-T waggle), Pass Protection (max protect and the launch point), The Quick Game (the now and bubble screens) and Dropback Concepts (the route combinations a fake is put in front of).

Sets up:

- Run-Pass Options: plays that are a run and a pass at once, and the one-yard rule that limits them; an RPO is not a fake but a real choice made after the snap.
- Linebackers and Run Fits and Box Math: the keys and run-fit triggers this chapter glossed, from the defense's side, and how defenses teach linebackers to survive play-action.
- Blitz and Man Pressure: the pressures screens punish.
- Constraint Theory and Sequencing: how play-action, boots and screens keep the base plays honest, and how play-callers sequence them.

See also (case study): The Shanahan Tree: Wide Zone, Boots, and the Illusion of Complexity and Andy Reid's Chiefs.

If you want to go deeper: Ben Baldwin's and Josh Hermsmeyer's 2018 play-action analyses (footnoted below) and Baldwin's later open-source work at Open Source Football; Chris B. Brown's *The Art of Smart Football* on the bootleg and the screen game; and any Shanahan-tree offense's All-22 film, watched with nothing but the linebackers' first two steps in mind.

[i](#) Go deeper

From diagrams to real tracking data. The animations in this chapter are gridiron simulations in NFL Big Data Bowl (BDB) coordinates, the format of the league's public tracking-data competition. The 2025 Big Data Bowl release (2022 season, weeks 1–9) records every player ten times a second, and its `plays.csv` marks each play's `playAction` and `dropbackType`, so you can find real bootlegs and watch the linebackers step up on the fake. The data needs a free Kaggle login, so this code is not run when the book is built.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

A play-action shot, aimed at the deep safety. Everything about the picture invites it. The defense has committed eight players to stopping the run, so only three defenders are deep enough to matter on a deep pass: two cornerbacks and one safety. The linebackers have been rewarded for shooting forward, so a good fake will move them. And the free safety, the only player who protects the middle of the field deep, is the one the fake targets: if he takes two steps forward when the back hits the line, a deep post goes over his head. Pair the post with a deep over route from the other side (the yankee idea in Figure 7) and he cannot cover both.

The down and distance make it cheap. On second-and-2, an incompleteness leaves third-and-2, still a comfortable running down. That is exactly why coaches call shots here and why the data in 01-02, showing most offenses run on second-and-short, matters: the defense *expects* the run, so the fake is believed.

What would make it a bad call? A defense that kept two safeties deep and played the run with seven, or a protection problem: the shot needs three seconds, so the offense keeps eight in to block.

Answer 2.

He has taken away the naked boot and given up the outside zone cutback. An end who stays home and waits for the quarterback is the one defender the naked bootleg cannot survive (Figure 5, right). But an end who stays home on the boot is not chasing the outside zone run from behind either, so on the real run the backside of the play is softer: the cutback lane he used to close is open.

Two good calls:

1. **Outside zone right**, and let the back cut back. The end's new habit has taken him out of the run play's backside pursuit.
2. **A protected bootleg** (Figure 6, left): the same fake and the same boot, but a guard pulls to kick the end out. The end is now a blocked defender, and the quarterback gets the edge he wanted. The risk is the tell of a pulling guard, which is why it is a call to make after the defense has adjusted, not before.

A third option is a **keeper the other way** (a run fake and the quarterback keeping it to the *play* side) if that end's teammates have also started leaving the run side early. This is how the play-action game talks to itself across a game: every adjustment the defense makes to stop one play loosens its grip on another.

Answer 3.

A slow screen to the running back, to the left. Three signs, in the order you should look for them:

1. **Linemen downfield before the throw.** The LT, LG and C have released past the line toward the left. On a normal pass that is a foul; here they are getting in front of the receiver. Their side is the screen side.
2. **Rushers let through.** The left end and tackle have been allowed to run free at the quarterback, who has drifted back to about nine yards to pull them deeper, so they will be far from the ball.
3. **The back slipping out.** He stepped up as if to block, and is now sliding out to the left behind the rushers, where the ball will come.

Why it is legal: the one-yard limit on linemen downfield applies only to passes thrown *beyond* the line of scrimmage. This pass will be caught behind it, so the linemen can be as far downfield as they like when the ball is thrown.

It is not a swing route: on a swing, the line keeps pass-blocking and the ball comes out in about a second. Here the line has released and the quarterback is still holding the ball at nearly two seconds, waiting for the rush to arrive and go by.